

Introduction to Contract Theory and Auctions

Bayesian Games

Prof. Alejandro Melo-Ponce



NAZARBAYEV
UNIVERSITY

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- The Buyer-Seller example from one of the previous lecture was an example of a **Bayesian Game**.
- In these games there is uncertainty over the payoff relevant (or possibly payoff irrelevant also) information in given pure strategy profiles.

Definition 4.1

A Bayesian game is a tuple $G = (N, \{A_i\}_{i \in N}, \Omega, \{T_i\}_{i \in N}, \{\tau_i\}_{i \in N}, \{\mu_i\}_{i \in N}, \{u_i\}_{i \in N})$ where

- $(N, \Omega, \{T_i\}_{i \in N}, \{\tau_i\}_{i \in N}, \{\mu_i\}_{i \in N})$ is a belief space.
- A_i is the set of **actions** of player i . $A = \prod_{i=1}^n A_i$ is the set of **action profiles**.
- $u_i : A \times \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is players i 's (state-dependent) utility function.

Definition 4.2

A **pure strategy** for player i is a function $s_i : T_i \rightarrow A_i$. A strategy of a player is a choice of action given her private signal realization. The **set of pure strategies for player i** is S_i and is the collection of all functions from T_i to A_i . The set of **pure strategy profiles** is $S = \prod_{i=1}^n S_i$.

Definition 4.3

A **behavioral strategy** for player i is a function $\sigma_i : T_i \rightarrow \Delta(A_i)$, that is, it is a choice of a probability distribution over actions given her private signal realization. The **set of behavioral strategies for player i** , $\hat{S}_i$, is the collection of all functions from T_i to $\Delta(A_i)$. The set of behavioral strategy profiles is $\hat{S} = \prod_{i=1}^n \hat{S}_i$.

Definition 4.4

Given a pure strategy profile $s = (s_1, \dots, s_n) \in S$, **player i 's ex-ante expected utility or payoff** is

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mu_i, s}[u_i] = \int_{\Omega} u_i(s_1(\tau_1(\omega)), \dots, s_n(\tau_n(\omega)), \omega) d\mu_i(\omega)$$

Definition 4.5

Given a pure strategy profile $s = (s_1, \dots, s_n) \in S$, **player i 's interim expected utility or payoff** is

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mu_i, s}[u_i | \tau_i = t_i] = \int_{\Omega} u_i(s_1(\tau_1(\omega)), \dots, s_i(t_i), \dots, s_n(\tau_n(\omega)), \omega) d\mu_i(\omega | \tau_i = t_i)$$

Definition 4.6

A **Bayes-Nash Equilibrium at the ex-ante stage** is a strategy profile $s^* = (s_1^*, \dots, s_n^*)$ such that no player can improve her ex-ante expected utility by changing unilaterally her strategy. That is, for all $i \in N$, all $s'_i \in S_i$, it holds that

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mu_i, s^*}[u_i] \geq \mathbb{E}_{\mu_i, (s'_i, s_{-i}^*)}[u_i]$$

Definition 4.7

A **Bayes-Nash Equilibrium at the interim stage** is a strategy profile s^* in which, for each player i and each type $t_i \in T_i$, it holds that

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mu_i, s^*}[u_i | \tau_i = t_i] \geq \mathbb{E}_{\mu_i, (s'_i, s_{-i}^*)}[u_i | \tau_i = t_i]$$

for all $s'_i \in S_i$.

Proposition 4.8

$BNE\text{-}interim \subseteq BNE\text{-}ex\text{-}ante$

Remark 4.9

Conversely, if Ω is finite and there is a common prior $\mu = \mu_1 = \dots = \mu_n$, then if s is an ex-ante BNE, then there is an $\tilde{s}$ that is an interim-BNE, and such that the probability, under μ , that $s_i(t_i) \neq \tilde{s}_i(t_i)$ is zero.

Example: An opponent of unknown strength

The row player's type is known, but the column player can be strong, with probability α , or weak, with probability $1 - \alpha$. The payoff matrices are:

		Column	
		F	Y
Row	F	-1, 1	1, 0
	Y	0, 1	0, 0

α

		Column	
		F	Y
Row	F	1, -1	1, 0
	Y	0, 1	0, 0

$1 - \alpha$

Example: Classical Adverse Selection

A firm A is taking over another firm B . The true value of B is known to B but unknown to A ; it is only known to A to be uniformly distributed on $[0, 1]$. It is also known that B 's value will flourish under A 's ownership: it will rise to λx , where x is the pre-takeover value and $\lambda > 1$. This description is common knowledge.

Example: Information can hurt!

In contrast with the single-agent case, more information can hurt both the informed and uninformed parties. Consider the following scenario: there are two states and two corresponding payoff matrices:

		Column		
		L	M	R
Row	T	1, 2	1, 0	1, 3
	B	4, 4	0, 0	0, 5

$\omega_1 : \text{prob. } 1/2$

		Column		
		L	M	R
Row	T	1, 2	1, 3	1, 0
	B	4, 4	0, 5	0, 0

$\omega_2 : \text{prob. } 1/2$

Example: Information can hurt! (continued)

Now suppose that player 2 is informed, while player 1 is uninformed, as before.

		Column		
		L	M	R
Row	T	1, 2	1, 0	1, 3
	B	4, 4	0, 0	0, 5

ω_1 : prob. 1/2

		Column		
		L	M	R
Row	T	1, 2	1, 3	1, 0
	B	4, 4	0, 5	0, 0

ω_2 : prob. 1/2

Example: Infection

Suppose that $T_1 = \{a, b\}$, $T_2 = \{a', b'\}$. Suppose the type maps are given by

$$\tau_1(\omega_1) = a, \tau_1(\omega_2) = \tau_1(\omega_3) = b, \quad \text{and} \quad \tau_2(\omega_1) = \tau_2(\omega_2) = a', \tau_2(\omega_3) = b'$$

		Column	
		L	R
Row	U	2, 2	0, 0
	D	3, 0	1, 1

ω_1 : prob. 9/13

		Column	
		L	R
Row	U	2, 2	0, 0
	D	0, 0	1, 1

ω_2 : prob. 3/13

		Column	
		L	R
Row	U	2, 2	0, 0
	D	0, 0	1, 1

ω_3 : prob. 1/13

Example: behavioral strategies

There are two players. Suppose that $T_1 = \{a, b\}$, $T_2 = \{c\}$, $\tau_1(t) = t_1$. The common prior is $\mu(a, c) = \mu(b, c) = 1/2$. The state games corresponding to each type vector are:

		Column	
		L	R
Row	T	1, 0	0, 2
	B	0, 3	1, 0

State game for $t = (a, c)$

		Column	
		L	R
Row	T	0, 2	1, 1
	B	1, 0	0, 2

State game for $t = (b, c)$

Example: Cournot's Duopoly with cost uncertainty

Two firms compete in selling a good: one firm does not know the other firm's cost function. Assume that both firms can produce the good at a constant unit cost. Assume also that they both know that firm 1's unit cost is c , but only firm 2 knows its own unit cost; firm 1 believes that firm 2's cost is c_L with probability θ and c_H with probability $1 - \theta$, where $0 < \theta < 1$ and $c_L < c_H$. Assume also that the inverse demand function is $P(Q)$ with $P(Q) > 0$ if $Q \in [0, \bar{Q})$ and 0 otherwise. Assume also that $P(Q)$ is differentiable.